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Culture (OWC): [Wolof \(MS30\)](#)

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Section Title(S)

LANGUAGE • TRADITIONS OF ORIGIN, EARLY MOVEMENTS AND INTER-TRIBAL RELATIONSHIPS

Jola and Serer: A Jola tradition, quoted among others by Wintz (1909, pp. v-vi), gives the Jola and Serer a common origin in Kabu (Haute Gambie and Portuguese Guinea) from which, because of internal quarrels, and probably also because of Mandinka and Fulbe pressure, emigration took place under two sisters, one (Anécho) establishing herself in the basin of the Salum and becoming the “mother” of the Serer, the other (Aguène) going to Casamance and becoming the “mother” of the Jola. A joking relationship exists between Jola and Serer to this day.

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Material Not Relevant

Mandinka and Serer: According to Ezanno (1919) the Serer of Fadiout came from Kabu under a Mandinka chief, Mansa Ali. Gambian traditions would seem to indicate that the original inhabitants of Nyomi were Serer, subject to the Wolof chiefs of Salum. They called in Mandinka and Fulbe warrior chiefs to help them in their struggle for independence. These took over the chieftainship of Nyomi, and in the course of time the country became Mandinka.

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Material Not Relevant

During the religious wars of the last century the people of the coastal region were attacked by the Mandinka and many were converted to Islam.

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Material Not Relevant

Serer and Bainunka: Béranger-Féraud (1879) considers that the Bainunka also entered into the composition of the Serer.

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Material Not Relevant

These traditions all suggest that the Serer represent the survivors of a primitive people who migrated westwards to the coast from various starting

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Material Not Relevant

points under Wolof, Mandinka, and Fulbe pressure, and were later dominated by these.

LANGUAGE

Serer is classified by Westermann and Bryan (1952) as a Larger Unit of the West Atlantic Languages. Earlier writers (Bérenger-Féraud, Faidherbe, Cust, etc.) divided the Serer language into two, Serer-Kégèm (Kéguem) or Ndyégèm (Ndjeguem), and Serer-Non (None), the latter subdivided into None, Faros, and Safi. De Tressan (1953, para. 534) classifies the numerous dialects as "true" and "false."

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Material Not Relevant

The group of "true" dialects includes:—

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Material Not Relevant

Sinsin (wrongly called Ndyégèm or Kégèm by Delafosse and Homburger), spoken in Sine.

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Material Not Relevant

Ndyégèm, the name of a group of six villages north of Ngasobil (Ndiémane, Ndolor, Sandiaye, Diokar, Oungoulbine, and Aga).

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Material Not Relevant

Baolbaol, spoken in Baol, and which is Sinsin, penetrated lexically by Wolof.

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Material Not Relevant

Fadyut-Palmerin ("dialecte de la petite côte"), spoken at Fadiout, south of Joal and at Palmerin Point. This differs phonetically and lexically from Sinsin.

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Material Not Relevant

The dialects of the islands of *Nyomi*.

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Material Not Relevant

The group of "false" dialects includes:—

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Material Not Relevant

Safènsafèn, spoken in the south-west of the canton Diobas (subdivision of Thiès) and in the cantons Mbayard-Nianing and Sandak-Diaganao of the subdivision of Mbour.

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Material Not Relevant

Non, at Doga, Saout, in the subdivision of Tivaouane, at Fandème, in the subdivision of Thiès, and in the canton Thor-Ndiendèr, around Thiès.

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Material Not Relevant

Ndut, at Pakoumkouye, Pallo, Loukhous, Tivagne-Diassène, Sambay-Maran, Mont-Roland, Foulom, in the subdivision of Tivaouane, as well as at Thiès.

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Material Not Relevant

Similarities between Serer-Kégèm and Fula have been pointed out by Greffier (1901), Guiraudon (1894), and Homburger (1939). Homburger regards Serer as an archaic form of Fula. Greenberg (1952) considers the relationship between Serer and Fula as obvious as the relationship between French and Italian. On the other hand de Tressan would not classify Fula and Serer together. It would appear that the relationship cannot be determined on the evidence available. The link lies between Fula and one dialect of Serer, but it is not known how much this Serer dialect resembles or differs from others. It is not even certain that Lamoise's or Greffier's dictionaries (from which most of the comparisons seem to have been made) include words of only one dialect. Furthermore, both the phonetics and grammatical analyses of these 100 early students of Serer are, by modern standards, faulty. Finally, it has to be decided with which dialect of Fula (in the absence of "basic Fula") it should be compared.

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Material Not Relevant

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